situations. India matters because it can make a real difference to global needs.

In recent times, India has heightened its international profile and displayed greater diplomatic energies. Regions and nations that were long neglected at the leadership level have been intensively engaged. Countries in the Gulf like the UAE got a prime ministerial visit after a gap of three decades and Bahrain the first ever in 2019. Similarly, Central Asian states like Turkmenistan and Kyrgyzstan waited for two decades and a key partner like Australia even longer, for 28 years! Even neighbours Sri Lanka and Nepal hosted an Indian PM bilaterally after long breaks. These endeavours have been supported by more systemic linkages across multiple domains. On important issues at global gatherings, India's voice has been stronger and effective.

But at the end of the day, much depends on the overall posture adopted by us. When our national security is at risk, it is essential to stake out positions and back our bets. If we were serious that there is no longer tolerance for terrorism, then an Uri or a Balakot had to happen. If our northern borders are threatened by China, then Covid or no Covid, the Indian armed forces will be counter-deployed. Even otherwise, a rising India must continuously push the envelope to expand its space. The pursuit of national interest is respected the world over, even by competitors. Doing what it takes is even more critical when it comes to core interests. This may apply to the safeguarding of its territorial integrity and sovereignty, combating terrorism, pursuing its economic interests and, indeed, in responding to global challenges.

Participation in the Quad is a recent example that has certainly enhanced India's standing in the world. Similarly, its stance on the Ukraine conflict resonates strongly with much of the Global South. We speak for them on energy security, food inflation and trade disruptions. India matters when it displays confidence, independence and determination.

Owing to its very uniqueness, India is not an easily replicable model. But it does offer experiences for others who are facing similar challenges. Indeed, the more it rises, the greater is the value of its achievements. The world recognizes both the singularity and the relevance of India's progress. Put aside those who harbour political prejudices; the rest get it that a civilizational state rising again will display its own personality. It will speak and think for itself, radiating how it is rooted in its own culture. The more